Using a multi-method approach, we show how IOs adapt to these challenges by diversifying their information sources and relying more heavily on one another. Our findings carry important implications for global governance. While states often join IOs based on shared security or economic interests, these organizations are increasingly interconnected. Populist threats have driven IOs to cooperate more closely, creating a global web of institutions that transcends their member states' original agreements. This interconnectedness can enhance IOs' power, enabling them to push their agendas more effectively and making it harder for states to exit or undermine the system.

In doing so, IOs not only safeguard their missions but also strengthen the overall resilience of the international order. As populists continue to challenge the global governance framework by manipulating information, IOs' ability to adapt and innovate will be crucial in maintaining a cooperative and effective international system.

4.1 How IOs Sideline Leaders

As discussed in chapter 2, sidelining is a widely employed strategy by IOs to work around uncooperative members. By reducing reliance on obstructive actors, sidelining allows IOs to mitigate risks posed by populist leaders who might withdraw their support or disrupt institutional processes. Unlike strategies such as appeasement, which require IOs to offer concessions or alter policies in meaningful ways, sidelining enables institutions to plug resource gaps without undertaking major reforms.

By doing so, they can not only secure critical information but also enhance their autonomy, which strengthens their ability to pursue long-term organizational goals without overreliance on individual states. Autonomy, as noted in prior research, can lead to improved institutional performance and resilience (Pollack 1997; Abbott and Snidal 1998; Johnson 2014), though potentially at the cost of agency slack (Barnett and Finnemore 1999). Even so, autonomy remains a critical asset for IOs navigating a politically volatile environment.

This chapter explores sidelining as a tool to address potential information deficits, a particularly attractive application given the wealth of alternative information sources in today's interconnected global landscape. IOs can